Himaayah Schools
SKILLS SCHOOL

FREE GUIDE

إِنَّ اللَّهَ كَتَبَ الْإِحْسَانَ عَلَىٰ كُلِّ شَيْءٍ

"Indeed Allah has prescribed excellence in everything." (Muslim 1955)

Design with Canva

A beginner's guide to graphic design: principles, colour and fonts, flyers, social posts and your first clients.

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمٰنِ الرَّحِيمِ

Before you begin

Every business, school, masjid and event needs flyers, posts and banners, and many people will pay for good ones. Canva is a free design tool that works on a phone or a computer, so you can start learning graphic design today without expensive software.

This guide teaches the basic principles of good design, how to use Canva step by step, how to design flyers and social media posts that look professional, the mistakes beginners make, Islamic adab in design, and how to build a small portfolio and earn from it. It ends with a 30-day practice plan.

> إِنَّ اللَّهَ كَتَبَ الْإِحْسَانَ عَلَىٰ كُلِّ شَيْءٍ
>
> **“Indeed Allah has prescribed excellence (iḥsān) in everything.”**
>
> Muslim, 1955.

Contents

01 **Getting started with Canva**
Account, home screen and the editor

02 **Six principles of good design**
The rules every designer follows

03 **Colour and fonts**
Choosing them well

04 **Your first flyer, step by step**

05 **Social media posts and sizes**

06 **Beginner mistakes**
And how to fix them

07 **Adab and honesty in design**
Images, copyright and content

08 **Building a portfolio and earning**

09 **Shortcuts and the 30-day plan**

Part 1 Getting started with Canva

1. Go to **canva.com** or install the **Canva** app, and sign up free with your email or Google account. Students and teachers may qualify for free premium plans through Canva for Education.
2. On the home screen, use **Create a design** and choose a type (Instagram post, flyer, poster, presentation) or enter custom dimensions.
3. In the editor, the **left panel** holds Templates, Elements, Text, Uploads and more. The **top bar** shows options for whatever you select. The **canvas** is in the middle.
4. Click any item to select it; drag to move; drag the corners to resize. Use **Position** to arrange layers and align items.
5. Your work saves automatically. Use **Share → Download** to export as PNG (best for social media), JPG, or PDF Print (best for printing).

Part 2 Six principles of good design

Principle	What it means	Quick test
Hierarchy	The most important thing is the biggest or boldest; then the next.	Can you tell what the design is about in 3 seconds?
Alignment	Items line up along clear edges or a centre line.	Turn on Canva's rulers and guides; does everything line up?
Contrast	Text stands out clearly from its background: dark on light or light on dark.	Could someone read it on a dim phone screen?
White space	Empty space around items lets the design breathe.	Is anything touching the edges or crowded together?
Repetition	The same colours, fonts and styles repeat, so it looks like one family.	Have you used more than two fonts or four colours?
Proximity	Related information sits together (date with time; phone with address).	Are the details grouped, not scattered?

Part 3 Colour and fonts

- **Pick 2 to 4 colours**: one main colour, one accent, and neutrals (white, black or grey). If a client has a logo, take colours from it with Canva's colour picker.
- **Use contrast for text**: avoid light yellow on white, or red on green.
- **Use at most two fonts**: one bold font for headings and one clean font for body text. Canva's **font combinations** in the Text panel are a good start.
- **Make text big enough**: on a phone post, the main heading should be readable at a glance.
- **Save a Brand Kit** (if available on your plan) with the colours, fonts and logo of each client.

Mood	Colours that often suit it
Calm, trust, Islamic events	Deep green, navy, cream, gold
Energy, sales, food	Red, orange, yellow
Clean, modern, tech	Blue, white, grey, one bright accent
Children, fun	Bright primary colours, rounded fonts

Part 4 Your first flyer, step by step

Practice brief: a flyer for a weekend Qur'an class at a local masjid.

1. **Gather the content first**: title, date, time, venue, contact and any key benefit. Check spelling with the client.
2. Create an **A4 flyer** or an **Instagram post (1080 × 1080)**.

3. Choose a **template** close to what you want, or start blank. Change its colours and fonts to fit the brief; never leave a template unchanged for a client.
4. Write the **heading** big: “Weekend Qur’an Class”. Add a short line underneath: “Learn to read with tajwīd. All ages welcome.”
5. Put the **details** in one group: date, time, venue, phone. Use icons from Elements if they help.
6. Add one **image or shape** that supports the message: a mushaf, a geometric pattern, or a soft background.
7. Check the six principles, zoom out to see it small, then **download as PNG** for WhatsApp or **PDF Print** for printing.

Part 5 Social media posts and sizes

Format	Size in pixels
Instagram or Facebook square post	1080 × 1080
Instagram portrait post	1080 × 1350
Story or Status (WhatsApp, Instagram, TikTok)	1080 × 1920
YouTube thumbnail	1280 × 720
X (Twitter) post image	1600 × 900
A4 flyer for printing	210 × 297 mm

Platforms change their sizes from time to time; Canva’s presets are usually current.

Part 6 Beginner mistakes

Mistake	Fix
Too much text	Cut it in half. Put details in the caption, not the image.
Too many fonts and colours	Two fonts, up to four colours.
Text over a busy photo	Add a dark transparent shape behind the text, or blur the photo.
Stretched or blurry images	Resize from the corners only; use high-quality images.
Everything is centred and the same size	Create hierarchy: make one thing big, and the rest smaller.
Spelling errors	Proofread twice and ask the client to approve before downloading.

Part 7 Adab and honesty in design

- **Choose images carefully**: avoid indecent images, and many Muslim designers avoid detailed images of people and animals for religious posters; use patterns, objects and calligraphy instead.

- **Respect copyright**: use Canva's licensed elements, free sites such as Unsplash or Pexels, or your own photos. Do not copy another designer's work or use logos without permission.
- **Handle the Qur'an and the names of Allah with respect**: check the Arabic is correct, and remember that printed designs with āyāt may be thrown away.
- **Do not design for ḥarām**: betting, alcohol, or deceptive advertising. Your skill is an amānah.
- **Be honest with clients** about deadlines, revisions and prices.

Part 8 Building a portfolio and earning

1. Design **10 practice pieces** for imaginary or real clients: a restaurant menu, a masjid event, a school poster, a business post.
2. Show them in one place: an Instagram page, a Behance profile, or a single PDF.
3. Offer your service to people you know: family businesses, your school, your masjid. Start with low prices or free work in exchange for a testimonial.
4. Agree the **brief, price, number of revisions and deadline** before you start.
5. Deliver on time, in the right sizes, and ask happy clients to recommend you. See our guide **Freelancing First Steps**.

Plan Useful shortcuts and a 30-day plan

Shortcut (computer)	Action
T	Add a text box
Ctrl + D	Duplicate
Ctrl + G	Group items
Ctrl + Z	Undo

Week	Practice	Done
1	Learn the editor; recreate 3 designs you like, for practice only.	☐
2	Design 3 social posts using the six principles.	☐
3	Design a flyer, a story and a YouTube thumbnail for one event.	☐
4	Make a 10-piece portfolio and offer your service to one real client.	☐

Test Self-test

Choose the best answer. The answers follow the questions.

1. Making the most important information biggest is called:

a) Repetition b) Hierarchy c) Proximity d) Contrast

2. **The best export format for printing a flyer is:**

   a) PNG b) PDF Print c) GIF d) MP4

3. **How many fonts should a beginner usually use in one design?**

   a) One or two b) Five c) As many as possible d) Seven

4. **The usual size of an Instagram square post is:**

   a) 500 × 500 b) 1080 × 1080 c) 1920 × 1080 d) 300 × 600

5. **Text over a busy photo is hard to read. A good fix is:**

   a) Make it smaller b) Add a dark transparent shape behind it c) Use more colours d) Remove the heading

6. **Before starting a client job, you should agree:**

   a) Nothing b) Only the price c) Brief, price, revisions and deadline d) Only the colours

No.	Answer	No.	Answer
1	b) Hierarchy	4	b) 1080 × 1080
2	b) PDF Print	5	b) A dark shape behind it
3	a) One or two	6	c) Brief, price, revisions, deadline

Learn a skill at the Himaayah Skills School

Short, practical courses with live practice and feedback: Public Speaking, Graphic Design and Data Analysis.

Learn more: himaayahschools.com/skills-school · **Enrol:** himaayahschools.com/enroll

General line (WhatsApp): +234 704 722 6487

وَمَا تَوْفِيقِي إِلَّا بِاللَّهِ

"And my success is only through Allah." (Hūd 11:88)

This guide is free to print and share. © Himaayah Schools, 2026.

Good design is a skill you can sell.

This free guide from the Himaayah Skills School teaches the principles of good design and how to use Canva, on a phone or computer, step by step.

- Six principles every designer follows
- Choosing colours and fonts
- Your first flyer, step by step
- Social media sizes and beginner mistakes
- A portfolio, adab in design and a 30-day plan

Learn a skill at the Himaayah Skills School

Short, practical courses with live practice and feedback: public speaking, graphic design and data analysis.

himaayahschools.com/skills-school